Kanoa Pick

Contact Information

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CV Last Updated November 9, 2026

Education

Ph.D. Expected Jun. 2029
Applied Ocean Science, Scripps Institution of Oceanography
Advisor: Falk Feddersen

M.S. Dec. 2025
Oceanography, Scripps Institution of Oceanography
Advisor: Falk Feddersen

B.S. Jun. 2024
Oceanic and Atmospheric Sciences, University of California San Diego
Advisor: Falk Feddersen
Minor: Engineering Mechanics

Professional Experience

Graduate Student Researcher Sep. 2024 – Present
Feddersen Group
Scripps Institution of Oceanography, University of California San Diego

Undergraduate Research Assistant Nov. 2021 – Sep. 2024
Feddersen Group
Scripps Institution of Oceanography, University of California San Diego

Journal Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles (Published & Accepted)

3. **Pick, K.**, Quinn, K., Cirrito, N., Domi, A., Tsampras, G., Feddersen, F. (2026). BathyBoard: A surfboard-based platform for measuring surf zone bathymetry. *Journal of Surveying Engineering* (accepted September 31, 2026).
2. **Pick, K.** & Feddersen, F. (2026). Scaling the shape of shoaling and overturning solitary waves. *Journal of Fluid Mechanics*, 1040 (A8). https://doi.org/10.1017/jfm.2026.11869
1. Feddersen, F., Amador, A., **Pick, K.**, Vizuet, A., Quinn, K., Wolfinger, E., ... Fincham, A. (2023). The Wavedrifter: A low-cost IMU-based Lagrangian drifter to observe steepening and overturning of surface gravity waves and the transition to turbulence. *Coastal Engineering Journal*, 66(1), 44–57. https://doi.org/10.1080/21664250.2023.2238949

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles (In Revision)

1. Cader, J., Ismail, R., Halualani, G., Aduja, A., Borras, M., Salem, M., Viloria-Winnett, A., **Pick, K.**, Cader, A., Bickart, K. (2026). Neurological symptoms in response to big wave surfing: a prospective pilot study of concussive events and ocean conditions. *Neurotrauma Reports* (in revision).

Honors & Awards

National Defense Science and Engineering Graduate (NDSEG) Fellowship	2026 – 2029
Best Oral Presentation, Young Coastal Scientists and Engineers Conference–Americas	2025
Best Paper Award, *Coastal Engineering Journal*	2024
Shores Scholarship, *University of California San Diego*	2021 – 2024

Presentations

Conference Oral Presentations & Research Seminars

8. Cader, J., Ismail, R., Halualani, G., Aduja, A., Borras, M., Salem, M., Viloria-Winnett, A., **Pick, K.**, Cader, A., Bickart, K. (2026). Neurological Symptoms in Response to Big Wave Surfing: A Prospective Pilot Study of Concussion Events and Ocean Conditions. *International NeuroTrauma Society Conference*, Oct. 25–29.
7. Cirrito, N., **Pick, K.**, Domi, A., Mack, C., Dooley, C., Young, D., Fiedler, J., O'Reilly, W., Young, A., Merrifield, M. (2026). A tower you can tow: automated beach morphology and wave runup from low-cost LiDAR. *Young Coastal Scientists and Engineers Conference–Americas*, Aug. 5–8.
6. **Pick, K.**, Feddersen, F., Tsampras, G. (2026). Effect of reef structures on wave breaking and overturning parameters. *International Conference on Coastal Engineering*, May 17–22.
5. **Pick, K.**, Feddersen, F., Tsampras, G. (2026). The effect of small engineered reefs on wave surfability. *Applied Ocean Sciences Seminar, Scripps Institution of Oceanography*, May 14.
4. **Pick, K.**, Feddersen, F., Tsampras, G. (2026). The effect of engineered reefs on wave breaking. *Ocean Sciences Meeting*, Feb. 22–27.
3. **Pick, K.** & Feddersen, F. (2025). Solitary wave overturning: Impact of beach slope and initial wave height. *Young Coastal Scientists and Engineers Conference–Americas*, Jul. 22–24.
2. **Pick, K.** & Feddersen, F. (2025). Solitary wave overturning: Impact of beach slope and initial wave height. *Waves In the Sea Environment Meeting*, May 12–15.
1. **Pick, K.** & Feddersen, F. (2025). Solitary wave overturning: Impact of beach slope and initial wave height. *Applied Ocean Sciences Seminar, Scripps Institution of Oceanography*, May 8.

Conference Poster Presentations

3. Denham, C., **Pick, K.**, & Feddersen, F. (2026). Effects of bathymetric profile curvature on solitary wave overturning shape. *Scripps Student Symposium, Scripps Institution of Oceanography.* Sep. 23.
2. **Pick, K.** & Feddersen, F. (2025). The effect of tide and reef position on wave overturn shape: Preliminary steps. *Scripps Student Symposium, Scripps Institution of Oceanography.* Sep. 23.
1. **Pick, K.** & Feddersen, F. (2024). Overturning characteristics of solitary waves: The effects of beach slope and incident wave height. *Scripps Student Symposium, Scripps Institution of Oceanography.* Sep. 18.

Professional Development Workshops

National Hazards Engineering Research Infrastructure (NHERI) Computational Symposium	Feb. 5-7, 2025

Mentorship

Charlie Denham, Undergraduate Researcher 2026 – Present
Scripps Institution of Oceanography
Mentoring an undergraduate research project using fully nonlinear potential flow wave modeling to investigate how quadratic bathymetric profiles influence the shape of overturning waves. Providing guidance in numerical modeling, study design, data analysis, and scientific communication.

Media

Featured in *Stab Magazine* profile Nov. 2026
Interviewed about my JFM research on how seafloor slope and offshore wave height shape barreling waves.

Research covered by Environment Coastal & Offshore Magazine Sep. 2026
Marine-industry coverage emphasizing implications for wave breaking and coastal sediment transport.

Research syndicated by Phys.org Sep. 2026
International science-news coverage of my JFM study's predictions of breaking wave shape.

Research profile in University of California San Diego Today Sep. 2026
Profile connecting my JFM research on breaking wave geometry with my experience as a surfer.

Scripps Institution of Oceanography science communication video and article Sep. 2026
Multimedia feature combining numerical simulations, surfing footage, and an accessible explanation of the study.

Featured in Surfline and Cliff Kapono's "Cliff Notes" video Aug. 2026
My JFM research on the shoaling and overturning of waves was featured in a surfing-focused science communication video that received more than one million views on Instagram.

Interview on *AirTalk* (LAist 89.3 FM / NPR) Jul. 2026
Discussed Hurricane Genevieve generated swell, coastal wave dynamics, and high-surf hazards in Southern California.

Interview with *CBS 8 San Diego* Jun. 2026
Discussed a large south swell affecting Southern California, including hazardous surf, rip currents, and beach safety.

Featured in *El Surf en California*, Surf Channel TV documentary Nov. 2025
Discussed research on the physics of breaking waves and highlighted notable surf breaks in the San Diego region.

Featured in Scripps Institution of Oceanography News Jun. 2024
Profiled in "Time to Celebrate the Graduating Class of 2024" for undergraduate research on coastal processes, wave breaking, and development of the Wavedrifter and BathyBoard.

Featured in Waves (Brazil) article — Aug. 2023

"Dispositivo desvenda mecanica das ondas". International coverage of research on the Wavedrifter, a novel instrument developed for measuring the dynamics of breaking waves.

Featured in SurferToday article — Aug. 2023

"Wavedrifter: The Device That Decodes the Breaking of a Wave". Highlighted research on the development and deployment of the Wavedrifter, a novel instrument for measuring wave steepening, overturning, and the transition to turbulence.

Member

American Geophysical Union — 2026 – Present

American Society of Civil Engineers — 2026 – Present

Skills

Numerical Models

OpenFOAM, fully nonlinear potential flow (FNPF) wave models

Programming & Computing

MATLAB, Python, LaTeX, Unix/Linux, Git, cluster computing

Field & Data Analysis

Emlid Studio PPK GNSS, single-beam echo sounders, ADCPs, pressure sensors, LiDAR, scientific scuba diving, and ATV operation

Field & Lab Experience

SHORECAL Experiment — Jul. 2026

Oahu, Hawaii

Prepared and deployed ADVs using scientific diving and boat operations off White Plains Beach.

Functional Surfing Reef Laboratory and Field Campaigns — 2024 – Present

San Diego, California and Ensenada, Mexico

Conducted laboratory experiments on small-scale artificial surfing reefs in the glass channel wave flume at the Scripps Institution of Oceanography Hydraulics Laboratory. Performed field deployment and recovery testing of reef anchoring systems at Scripps Beach, followed by full-scale reef deployments and monitoring in Todos Santos Bay, Baja California, Mexico.

BathyBoard Surf Zone Bathymetric Surveys — 2023 – Present

Oahu, Hawaii, and San Diego, California

Planned and conducted GNSS and single-beam echo sounder surveys from a surfboard platform in energetic surf zone environments; supported equipment preparation, deployment, and recovery.

Rocky shOrelines eXperiment SImulation (ROXSI) — 2022 – 2026

Monterey, California, and St. Thomas, U.S. Virgin Islands

Calibrated, programmed, deployed, and recovered ADCPs and pressure sensors using scientific diving and boat operations along rocky coastlines.

Long-Term Beach Profile Monitoring — 2021 – 2024

San Diego, California

Conducted long-term monitoring of beach morphology using GNSS equipped ATVs, truck mounted LiDAR, and GNSS push dollies to collect high-resolution topobathymetric surveys of Southern California beaches. Participated in repeated surveys supporting investigations of shoreline change.

Wavedrifter Field Campaigns 2021 – 2023

California, Hawaii, and Tahiti

Deployed and recovered Lagrangian drifters in breaking waves to measure wave steepening, overturning, and the transition to turbulence.